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Bob Cranshaw

Bassist Bob Cranshaw could create an extraordinary resume of his career. He was born in Evanston, Illinois in 1932 and started on the piano and drums, later taking up bass in high school. His first professional work came in Chicago with the MJT+3 with Walter Perkins. His move to New York in 1960 enabled him to join forces with jazz giant Sonny Rollins and this longstanding relationship still flourishes today. Bob has performed with Lee Morgan, Wes Montgomery, Horace Silver, Ella Fitzgerald and Joe Williams, and the list goes on. He is equally at home with the acoustic or electric bass and became a first call player in the New York studios. Countless children have heard the bass of Bob Cranshaw during the years he spent as the resident bassist for Sesame Street.

Bob was interviewed by Michael Woods on October 18, 1995 in New York City.

MW: We are here in New York City and we are filming for our Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. We have with us today one of the most renown bass players, studio musician and overall musician in the United States, Bob Cranshaw.

BC: Thank you. Pleased to meet you and pleasure to be here.

MW: Yeah. You are an outstanding bass player. And you've been on just a scad of recordings. But how did you get started? First of all what attracted you to the bass as to other instruments.

BC: I'm really a percussionist. I started out wanting to be a concert percussionist. I was not really interested in jazz at all but I wanted to be a classical percussionist. But my father was a drummer who grew up with Count Basie, grew up in Kansas City, so he goes back to the Count Basie early days, and I have a brother who is a pianist who is also in New York and worked briefly with Miles years ago. And I have a brother who is a vibist. So since my father was also a drummer, I figured there was no reason for me to buck — I just wanted to play anything. I wanted to play with the family. And since he was a drummer, I wasn't going to move him over, he was there first. So I decided to play bass. And I liked choral music a lot. And in school and in high school and in college I was always involved in choirs and I wanted to kind of be a choir director. And my father was a choir director for the church so I got a chance, I was always around music and I just decided to play bass. So my brother would sit down at the piano and I guess this was in say maybe '49 or '50, I started to study the bass. And I really had a hard time trying to learn the instrument. I mean it wasn't really easy. But I wanted to play football. I was also a football player, and I was more interested. You know I wasn't sure whether I liked bass or what was happening. But I started to think about what would happen to my hands first. That was one of the major things the orchestra director would say well you're

playing football, but what about your hands? What if something happens to your hands? And eventually he won out. I finally really got serious about the string bass and I studied with a teacher at Northwestern University. I'm from Evanston, Illinois, so I spent a lot of time at Northwestern. And I graduated from Roosevelt University in Chicago in Musical Therapy. But I've been working as a musician for years and never really gotten into the musical therapy, but that's kind of how I got around to the string bass. And once I got into it I had such a rough time, I just decided to stay with it. I never tried to play drums again. And it's been years of all bass bass.

MW: Let me ask you, you said that your orchestral director was talking about your hands. So did you study classically? You studied with the bow?

BC: Yeah. I studied classically.

MW: You know this is just my observation, I find people that have studied with the bow have incredibly solid intonation.

BC: Yeah. I mean I never thought about really wanting to be, as far as a bass player I wanted to get involved with the symphony with the bass. I guess the teacher that I studied with in Chicago, his prize student was Richard Davis. And at that time, Richard and I are around the same age and Richard was already, they were already priming him for the Chicago Symphony at that point you know, but he passed it up. But he was really an excellent player. I didn't get into it that deep you know. I wish I had, but coming from a musical family and being around music, I learned to, I started out playing piano when I was about four. And I played piano by ear. So I think I studied maybe a year or two with a teacher, and after two years I found out I was playing everything by ear. The teacher would play my lesson for the next week so once I heard it I had no problems, I'd go out and play baseball. And my brother would practice the piano and I would be outside playing baseball and go right back to my lesson and play exactly what she played. So it kind of gave me an in when I started to play the bass, my brother would play a chord, and I would find the note to fit the chord. And because I had an ear it was easier for me to play. So I kind of learned to read, but I kind of use both situations since God gave me the ear, I didn't throw it away. I just also use my ear and I think it kind of hurt in the way that I didn't follow through probably with like the studies, because I already heard, you know, if I heard a piece it was all I needed. I could play it. Once I heard it, it was over.

MW: Well I want to ask you something about that and give me your feedback on this, because to me jazz is a music that the best jazz to me still emanates from oral culture. That means you've got to have an ear. And yet it's so sophisticated now you've got to have some training too.

BC: Yeah. But for me, I think it enabled me to be able to do a lot of things you know? Because I can go out on a job when well I've heard the music or whatever. I'm never

frightened as to what, you know, music in front of you, then that's another story because it's there so you don't have a chance to do you know those things. And it took me a long time to really learn to read because I had depended upon my ear for so many years that it took again, a lot of practice to learn to read. But I was determined that I was going to win that battle also. And I did. But the ear part has just helped me, especially with the jazz things. I just, again, I don't, I play what I hear. I know the chords and things to the tune, but I can follow. You can go where you want to go, you can change keys, you can do whatever you like to do. I would rather you not tell me 'cause I'm not thinking about it. I'm only thinking about what I hear, you know. So working with a lot of piano players like Monty Alexander and working with Erroll Garner and people like that who play by ear. I mean Monty and I, we would play and start a tune in one key, and we could end up in another key, and not really, we didn't really think about it. It was nothing that we thought we were in another key, it felt like the key that we were in. I mean we would just go off on tangents with just playing. And it was wonderful for me because it gave me a chance to use — God I feel gave me the talent and the ear to be able to hear, so I didn't see any reason why not to use it. It is that I have to use it with the academics. Then I finally got into that and I got really deep into it, so I'm thankful that I did, now, with the studio things and being able to do other things besides just play what I hear or being intimidated by going someplace and they put music there and, oh my God, I can't read it, you know.

MW: So in other words, you can go all three ways. If they give you notes, if they give you changes, or if they just ask you to hear the forms.

BC: Yes.

MW: That's marvelous. And of course we're filming this at our college, and I'm glad that students are hearing this, that it takes a combination of those skills. Tell us when you first started working with Sonny Rollins.

BC: I worked with Sonny, starting I think in 1959 or '60. Sonny — I played the first Playboy Jazz Festival. And I met Sonny before around Chicago, but I never worked with Sonny, usually Victor Sproles or different bass players who were a little older usually worked with Sonny, and who were more established. And one day Sonny heard Walter Perkins the drummer and I, who, we came as a package you know. We worked a lot of jobs at the London House and different places on the off nights for Oscar Peterson, and people like that, we would work opposite them one night and spell another band that was there on Mondays and Tuesdays. So I got a chance to meet a lot of the name people and play opposite them. But it gave me a chance to meet a lot of people. And through this one day Sonny was doing the Playboy Festival, and he asked Walter Perkins to do it and he said, "Walter, get the bass player who you would like." So I was hired. We played the festival,

it was really a very funny situation 'cause it was in the afternoon on a Sunday afternoon. Sonny Rollins told us to be there I think the concert maybe started at one o'clock or two, I think about two. Sonny said well be there, ready to play at one. I get there, and we don't see no Sonny. Two o'clock comes, the concert starts, the first group plays, fifteen, twenty minutes. The second group, fifteen or twenty minutes. The third group was a Dixieland band. And we were the fourth group to go on. The Dixieland band played ten minutes, fifteen minutes, twenty minutes, a half an hour. They're waiting now for Sonny to come in. The Dixieland band played I think for at least forty minutes. By that time people were wiped out with hearing the band. They were looking now, they were ready to hear Sonny. Still no Sonny. Come to find out when the people started to really get tired, all of a sudden Sonny comes out. Sonny had probably been in the auditorium since eleven o'clock, just casing everything. But he picked his time to want to come out. And we just tore the place up. And it was just a trio. Just bass, drums and saxophone. No rehearsal, we just played. And it was a wonderful experience. Now Sonny hadn't really come out at that time, he was still in retirement. But that was the only thing that he had work, and he asked me at that time would I like to be a part of his group. So I said sure, you know. But I never thought that Sonny Rollins, you know, come on, it's like a joke, but I'll go along with it, it's okay, I appreciate you asking. About a year and a half later he wrote me letters. We didn't start right away. About a year later he finally said, "I'm ready to put this group together." It was Walter Perkins, Jim Hall and myself. And that goes back to I guess 1960 or 61. I've been with Sonny over 35 years. I'm still on and off, I would leave, I left and Sonny went with Joe Williams. 'Cause Sonny's group at this time we were playing I guess it was Don Cherry and Billy Higgins. And it was more free form. And although I enjoyed, I got a lot out of it, I didn't feel that I was really adequate for the role. I like to play changes. I'm not a free form, you know, I need guidelines, restrictions, or whatever. I needed a more structured situation. So I stayed with Sonny for a while, and it got kind of loose to me and I didn't want to put the music down that we were doing, it just was not exciting to me. But I knew Sonny, being the genius that he is, he was ready for that step. I wasn't ready for it emotionally. Musically I could have probably accepted it. But emotionally I didn't really feel good. And I didn't want players to feel like I was putting them on by just playing I mean you know just anything, I just didn't feel right about it. So I left and went with Joe Williams to play the blues. I needed to come back to what I was familiar with.

MW: Okay now I got to ask you something. I got to ask you something. Tell us, is blues — why you say you had to play the blues? Tell us how and why or in your own words how blues is an anchor. Why does it seem like so much music comes back to that? Even when

a guy's taking a solo and he's out there and he's saying something abstract and he wants to come back down home, he'll play that blues scale.

BC: Because it's so much, not only are the changes just right, but the feeling of the music, you know. I mean Joe, I grew up on Joe Williams. I mean I can say as a young guy, I was young at that time and it was just right for me. Because Joe's stuff was very structured. But he was such a professional. We would get on the stage and we were swinging. I mean the music felt so good. Every night it was just very consistent. And the trio was Junior Mance and Mickey Roker. And we had a good time with each other but it was a thrill to play with Joe Williams because I just grew up. I mean I became a man with Joe Williams. He gave me that foundation you know and how to greet people, how to be, and not only that he introduced me to some of the most influential people in my life. One was Milt Hinton. Joe Williams did a lot of recordings with Milt Hinton and Jimmy Jones or Hank Jones and Osie Johnson. And I got a chance to sit and just watch these people. Any record date he had I was there. But any time Milt Hinton would record I would follow him around like a puppy. If Milt Hinton had a date, I just wanted to see how Milt Hinton and George Duvivier, how they approached music. And I would ask questions with Joe if they played something. I knew that after they finished recording it, I was going to have to play it. Because this is what we would do in our performances. So it was like catching first hand the master play it, and then I could branch off of what they were playing because they might have used a larger group maybe with horns, where when we got ready to play it we had to do it with a trio. But I was there. I wanted to understand everything about that tune and what I could do. And I would ask Milt Hinton, you know, well why did you play this there, well why did you play this F here as opposed to playing it there, what did you hear here. I wanted to know everything that Milt Hinton was doing. And I became, I feel like I'm a Milt Hinton clone in a way, because I enjoy watching Milt, how he carried himself and what a gentleman he is, and how great, I used to walk in and I'd be sitting at a record date, and I'd be like kind of hiding. I just didn't want to, you know, bug him. And I would wait until he came in. And it could be a record date with fifty musicians. When Milt Hinton walked in the door, you felt an energy, you know, it was something like a storm just hit the place. I mean it was so great. And I enjoyed that feeling. So I said this is what I would like to be. This is the way I would like to carry myself. This is what I would like to become, you know. And it maybe kept me from doing some of the things, because during that period a lot of the musicians were into a lot of drugs.

MW: Okay I have to say something. I'm going to come back to that. 'Cause you're saying something that's really precious. Now I want to come in right here and finish up on something on Joe Williams. And then we're going to come back to that. That's terribly

important. But tell us about Joe Williams as a vocalist. What could singers today learn from Joe?

BC: Joe could do everything. He could sing a ballad — any tune — he's one of the few people, anything that he wanted to sing he could sing. He had the voice, he had the range, he had the presence to really carry it off, you know. And I just remember some of the places that we used to go — to Toronto. We worked there a lot. And in the audience would be Oscar Peterson and his trio. And they'd enjoy it. I mean we would be cooking you know. I mean it was just an honor. I never felt that our performance was not worthy of whatever, because it was so consistent. It was just great. Every night I couldn't wait for Joe to hit the stand. Because some of the tunes were just gorgeous. And I mean I go back, I talked to Ray Brown's wife, and she remembers the times that we used to, they used to come and catch us in San Francisco and it was just burning. I mean it was incredible you know. It felt so good I wanted to scream, it was just that great. But Joe was very patient with me as a young player, and talking to me, and trying to keep me from running all over the place. I was married, and to keep my family thing. I mean he was really, he was instrumental in me becoming a man I mean I feel.

MW: He was more than a musician, wasn't he?

BC: Yeah. A wonderful person. I had a great time with Joe Williams.

MW: Now I want to come back in and say you said that there was a lot of things going on, a lot of trouble that a young man could get into. But the music and the masters of the music kept you away from it. Elaborate on that.

BC: Well Milt Hinton was one of the masters. One of the things that was funny, when I came to New York I came, I had a decent bass, but I had a bass case that was so raggedy. I mean it was in bad shape. And I used to go to clubs until Milton looked at this bass case and he said, "Son, you can't be going around with a case like this." So he donated a, he gave me a bass bag. 'Cause he was embarrassed. But it showed me, I mean he was just so, his demeanor at that time. When I came to New York, there was a lot of jobs. There was a lot of studio things happening. And every, ABC, CBS and NBC they all had studio orchestras. And so Clark Terry and a lot of these guys that a lot of people don't know were in these bands. But the bands didn't have T.V. shows to play, so they were kind of getting paid but they were doing all kinds of record dates. They would run from one studio, and it was really exciting. I used to stand right around the corner here on 53rd and Broadway, and just watch the guys run back and forth to the record dates, and you know, it was exciting. It was a very exciting time period. And that was in the late 50s and the 60s. It was just very exciting. You know all of the people, but Milt Hinton and Hank Jones and guys really were role models for the younger guys. There was a group who were already into what we were talking about the drugs. I mean that was a separate

situation happening. But the Milt Hintons and people like that they were just, they were wonderful. I mean Milt Hinton, I still, he's just marvelous. He's just a marvelous person. And I wanted to be Milt Hinton. I wanted to be this. The next Milt Hinton was my dream. I just wanted to be like he was. And Joe and Milt and all of them were very close. So hearing their experiences, trying to re-live some of the experiences that I had heard them talk about, and so forth, was just wonderful. And I think I caught maybe the tail end of a period that was just incredible. And the young guys now, we don't have the same thing going. I feel kind of bad. Because we didn't do the same. They did this for us and I don't think we did the same for the kids who are coming up now, which I'm trying to make up because I'm trying to work more with young people and do more with the union and different situations. Because I understand a lot more of what is happening and things to be able to say to a younger musician coming up now. Because it's very hard. It's difficult. We have wonderful people coming out of colleges, but I don't know where they're going. I don't know. The competition, you know — whether it's classical music or whatever — the competition is fierce. It's incredible. And there's so many great players.

MW: Has competition replaced camaraderie?

BC: Yeah. 'Cause they don't have a chance. We don't have enough situations that keep us together for the camaraderie. At the time when I came to New York there were clubs all over the place. There were great musicians who were not big names, but they were great, they could play. You could walk to one corner and I mean I didn't even want to sleep because I would go to a club and hear a group and they'd sound so good I'd go home and I'd either want to break the bass or I'd want to start to practice, you know. It was that kind of thing going. After hearing the Milt Hintons I mean you'd go home and you were shaking, it was so exciting. You didn't know where to start next. I remember Ron Carter and I used to stand on the corner of 53rd and talk. And we called ourselves the "super subs." I was never going to a job if Milt Hinton was called to the job, he was first. He and George Duvivier. I wasn't, I didn't want to mess with that. I didn't even want anybody to consider me being first call you know. I might have been fifth call. But it was okay. Because the people who were before me were so great, I didn't mind being fifth or sixth. So we called ourselves the "super subs." 'Cause when we went in on a job we could really take care of business. We both knew that we were good enough to do, but I wasn't going to throw myself in and say that I was greater than the people who were the number ones and number twos on the job. I didn't even think about that. If Milt Hinton got a call for a job, I was just there to hear what he was playing and to watch it go down. But I didn't want to be called. I was praying that they wouldn't call me you know. Call them

first, and if they couldn't do it, they would call me and I would go in for them. But don't even think about calling me.

MW: But it felt good to be a member of the club.

BC: Yes. It felt good that they were looking at me, saying okay, this is a great thing. We have something great coming following us. They felt good that they were building something that they had faith in. And Ron and I were one of the two, and Richard Davis, that they thought a lot of and they felt good about us coming up. We were college trained. We had all of the increments of being great in whatever was happening next, so they were very open to it.

MW: Tell us — two things I want you to elaborate on a little bit. You played on a lot of television shows. Tell us about your work on *Sesame Street*.

BC: Oh, great. It was a great experience.

MW: We see the shirt right here.

BC: Yeah. But I was 27 years with *Sesame Street*. It started out, I started to work, Joe Raposo was the first writer, was the musical director for the show and I fell into the job through Chuck Israels, another bass player who was in New York. And Chuck was doing an off-Broadway show called "House of Flowers." And he was leaving, going to the state of Washington to teach at a university there. So he called me and asked me if I was interested in doing this off-Broadway show for him. He was leaving. So I said yeah I would be glad to do it. And when I went down, they were having a lot of problems between, with the rhythm section. They were all arguing all the time with each other 'cause I guess they were not getting a good feeling from the music. And the conga player didn't like the bass player, and this one. So I went in and I listened to the show. I went down one evening to hear it before Chuck left. And I could hear the chaos. I knew what was happening. Some of it was personalities. Some of it was musicianship. But I heard it. And the next day I went in to play the show and it felt so good. We had so much fun, until Joe Raposo and I, Joe played piano a lot different than piano players that I was accustomed to playing with. Because I was playing with Hank Jones and Jimmy Jones and all of these great people. Not that Joe was not great, it was just a different sound. He didn't comp. He played everything. He played the bass in his left hand, so I heard what was happening and I said okay, this is the way I've always accepted the way another person plays. So when I hear that, I try to blend what I do with what they're doing. I heard the way Joe heard, the ear started again. I could hear the music, but I could hear what Joe was doing. And I became his left hand. So he knew that I was there, regardless to what he played, I was right on top of him and I heard it and I didn't put him through, I didn't want him to have to change anything he was doing. I could adopt what I was doing. What I did was take his left hand and just make it feel good to him. That's all I

did. I knew, this I got from the Joe Williams kind of thing. And the Milt Hinton. If it feels good, I like things that really feel good. I can listen to a band play out of tune, but if it feels good, if they have a certain kind of energy, I'm attracted to it. And I was attracted to the Milt Hintons and the people like that because of the energy that I heard. The Oscar Peterson trio, I'm a big fan of Ray Brown. I'm a kind of Ray Brown clone. I like that excitement. I like that kind of energy. And I feel that's the kind of energy that I have. So I'm drawn to bass players and musicians more so who have that energy. These are the people who I enjoy working with more than others. I can work with any musician, but I have my preference as to what the feeling is. Because I'm kind of blues feeling when I'm playing with Sonny. My job is to set up the groove, the pocket. I don't have to solo. I never made myself a soloist or got into all of that. I never wanted to be a big deal. But if it felt good, I was a big deal. Because I know that people come in, they understand, they hear music, but they like what they feel. And I'm feeling, from Milt Hinton again we go back to that situation. So this is kind of how my whole thing, how I evolved with Joe Raposo. We just locked. And from that time until his death, everything that Joe Raposo, all of his ventures, whether it was a Broadway show, movies, I was always involved. Because he never had to worry about what he did. I never disturbed his thing. I just made his thing feel good. And I know I did. So I had an accomplishment.

MW: You had the ability to diagnose, at speed, on the spot.

BC: Yeah. I can hear and I know that that bass is important. We need, bass players are very important. But I didn't want to change, he didn't play, he played the pump and he was always playing the bass note. But I didn't mind. I could hear what he was doing, and as long as I could hear it, you know, I said look, why disturb what he was doing? It's okay. If we play the same note it's okay. I don't mind that. But it's going to feel good. I'm going to make the note that he played, it's going to feel so good to him. He's going to enjoy playing it. And so I was not only playing different music but I was in with a different group of guys than I would ordinarily work, I would probably never have worked with a Joe Raposo or the drummer Danny Epstein. And we had a trio. We started to work, and then I got into *Sesame Street* with Joe Raposo playing and a guy named Danny Epstein. I had never played with a drummer who played, I mean after playing with the Art Taylors and the Philly Jo Jones and the Mickey Rokers and so forth, I started to play with this guy Danny Epstein. And I used to, he was a Jewish guy from Forest Hills. And we would play a tune and I'd tell him to play "Forest Hills Rock" you know he was always asking me well how should I play this? I'd say just play "Forest Hills Rock." Just play what you play. But he had such a wonderful feeling too. We just had a blend. And we enjoyed each other. We would come in and we'd play and we would laugh. And I started to send other bass players when I started to work *Sesame Street* after a while, I'd

send in Walter Booker and a lot of other guys who also enjoyed the experience that I was having working with this group of guys. I would do this during the day and at night I was working with Billy Taylor. So I got the chance to enjoy all of it. I had my cake and I ate it too.

MW: Oh, that's great. That's about as good as it gets for a musician. I want to ask you to elaborate on one thing here for us. You, I've heard you, through our conversation so far, again and again talk about the feel of music. And then you talked about having fun with the music and laughing and the grooves that you get into. Kind of give us your take on why those things are so essential to jazz. Not that orchestral music or chamber music doesn't have a given energy. But talk to us from the jazz standpoint of why those things are vital.

BC: Well I just think it's very important. In the classical thing the music is based more on the conductor, who, if it's a conductor with charisma, with that energy, I mean these things in the orchestra usually come through, they have that pop. I mean in Chicago I used to go and listen to the Chicago Symphony. And they would be cooking. Cooking. I mean you know it was all I could do to sit still, because the energy or what the orchestra was about, generally was so great. And in jazz, I just feel it's important. I think right now we're kind of getting away from some of those things because most of the players are studied players but they're not thinking about playing time. They learn to play, but they're not thinking about whether it feels good or whatever. It's like I'm playing, I hate to go and play for an audience and they say well, this is what I did, like it or not. I want them to like. I want to see that they like it. You know I want to leave with that feeling that boy, you know, they left, they really enjoyed this. That what I went through, the experience that I went through, that we both had it together, the audience and I, we both experienced this great thing together. And this was a Joe Williams thing. I knew it was there. I didn't have to look for it. When we got through I was so proud to come off the stage. I felt very good, and I was just a little part of whatever was happening. Joe was the bigger part. But it was just a joy it was a pleasure to do it. And I guess I worked with Joe for two or three years. I mean it was just an honor. So those kind of things — I'm a feeling player. But I grew up listening to the Oscar Peterson trio that used to cook, that I listened to daily, that I had an opportunity to play opposite for many days. And I would come off the stage and we had a trio with a guy named Eddie Higgins and Walter Perkins and I. And Eddie was going to Northwestern. We were both at Northwestern and we would play opposite Oscar Peterson. And we had a great trio with Eddie, but of course Oscar and Ray and Ed Thigpen wiped us out, you know, he washed it. But it was okay. I didn't mind it for a minute. You know they would stay for a month at the London House and for a month —

MW: It's okay to get wiped out by people like that.

BC: But now the next group that came in, I remember being wiped out by Oscar Peterson and the next group that came to the London House was Jonah Jones. And Jonah Jones caught it, cause we took out Oscar. Jonah and the group had to be playing. Whoever came in next, would really be playing other than that. Because we were wounded you know. We were animals and we were wounded so we needed to come back. But it was a nice pride and we looked to get washed, and we knew we were like the "Junior Oscar Peterson" because Eddie, like Oscar; I was a Ray Brown clone; and Walter was probably the only one who had his own individual thing. But Walter was such a great time player. And he had such a groove, the only person that I could think that had a groove on drums like Walter Perkins was Art Blakey you know. He had such a groove. He could sit down and the stuff would just swing. As soon as he hit, it was just gone. So there are people that have that ability and Walter Perkins was one of those people. And I stayed with Walter, we became like a duo. Any time you saw Walter Perkins, Bob Cranshaw wasn't far behind. 'Cause we seemed to lock, and have such an enjoyable time in playing. We would go around Chicago and we would finish work with Eddie Higgins and then we would go another club. And as soon as Walter and I walk in the door you could hear the people start to buzz. 'Cause they knew we were going to sit in. We would sit in and play two tunes, and just burn. And then we'd leave and go someplace else, you know. So it was a wonderful feeling. And I came up with that kind of thing. But it started also from church music. My father was a choir director and I used to enjoy hearing the choir. First I wanted to sing but I was too young. So I used to just sit there and hear the choir and I'd cry. I wanted to sing bass so bad. That's another part of the bass thing. I wanted to sing bass.

MW: So it's a voice for you? The bass is a voice, isn't it?

BC: Yeah.

MW: Okay.

BC: It is a voice. It is a football thing, you know. It's the bottom, it's the stability or whatever, you know the lineman is the linebacker, it's that thing that holds the glue to the whole band, so I think in wanting to sing bass. But I'd listen to my father. I'd go in and I'd listen to the choir and I would go in the basement of the church and I would just sit downstairs and I would listen and I could hear the music. But the rhythms of all the people in the church and the thing, they would be burning. I mean it felt so good. That was the part that was really great to me that I liked. The feeling was just incredible.

MW: You know I want to say, just make an interjection here and want you to come back on that a little bit. Many, many of the players we've interviewed so far have said that an initial energy, a sense of spirituality, not religiously, not in a pious way, but a sense of spiritual energy, they've gleaned from church.

BC: Yeah. There's no doubt about it. I mean my feelings have to come from that experience. I and I would just go to different churches in Evanston and I would go to the basement. I wouldn't go upstairs. I just wanted to hear what was the interplay between what happened with the music, and what rhythms that people had in their feet, and all of that. It would feel like that the roof, you know feel like the floor was going to cave in, 'cause there was such a great feeling, great energy. And I think as a musician, I'm more drawn to again, a band with this kind of energy. I can like other things. I can like rock groups, I can like certain groups, but I enjoy the energy of the group. If they have that energy, that's why I'm a Steely Dan fan. They have an energy. Not only do they incorporate jazz things, but they have such an energy to the band going. I mean it's just incredible. I couldn't stay still and listen. I mean I love it.

MW: I want to ask you a couple of more questions here. Where is jazz going and/or where does it need to go?

BC: It's hard to say because now we find out that jazz can make money. Before, there was money being made we didn't realize it, we didn't get most of it, but you know, we wanted to play. I say now when I go in, when I used to play in the pit and do Broadway shows, I always wondered, I tell musicians, because I'm working a lot for the musician's union, not as a representative but as a person who was plugged in to the system by no fault of mine. I got plugged into the system and now I'm getting back I get a large pension, so that if I didn't work another day in my life I'm really very well taken care of, my wife and I. So I'm a fortunate individual. If they would have given me the money I'd have spent it. But because somebody else put it in, so trying to talk to the younger musicians about the system and the different things that they can get involved in, which most of them are not involved in. I mean the younger guys coming up, there's nowhere for them to play. We could go and play in Birdland. We had all of these places to play, I was invited to play. I mean I think back — Milt Hinton allowed me to play with Bing Crosby. Now I was a young guy, and I walked in and Milt Hinton had more work than he could do. And at Lincoln Center, I walked in to play the bass with Bing Crosby and Bing Crosby looked and he said, "Oh, shit" you know he said, "this guy's too young. He ain't going to know these tunes." He didn't know I was older than he thought I was and I knew the material. But it was just strange for him to see this young guy. But Milt had already started to build me and to give me the experiences that he thought I needed to do. The young guys now don't have an opportunity for those experiences. The record companies, it's a money making situation. So if the record company takes a young guy who is promising, they start to work. I mean it's not about the other things. And they almost make the younger musicians forget where you came from, forget all of that, this guy is an old guy, so that was already done. So they're more or less trying to create, we have great

guys coming out of the schools and so forth but I think that management and the music business has taken another look at it and said — hmmm, people are starting to like jazz. All those commercials I hear, everything is jazz now you know. And it's a money making situation and most of the kids have no idea, they're not in touch with the culture. With Josh Redman and so forth, Josh never has the time to spend with some older players or to see the older players, because they're already moved aside, because of money or because of management. If you call and you want to get a younger player on a record date, you've got to go through the manager to get him, which is okay because music is music business. I mean I also talk to kids, it is music is music business regardless to whether you're involved in classical playing or whatever, it is still a business. But we just looked at it as music. I mean we hoped that we were able to make money to feed our families from what we were doing, but it was fun. It was more fun at that time I think. And it's hard for me, my son is a bass player and it's hard for me to relate. I tell him stories but those stories don't hold true to the younger guys now, that the guys when I was working with Joe Williams and we were around the Basie band. The experiences and stories that these guys were living and talking about, I couldn't wait to experience the same things. You know, when is it my turn? You know, right now, the younger guys don't have the time, don't have the chance to get into any of that. If they seem to be a little above the norm, they're taken and put to the side, and then they start their careers. Somebody else tells you this is where your career is going. This is what you do, this is what you should do. So we don't have a hands-on and they don't have a chance to play with enough people or to work, enough experiences. They come out and they're stars. The younger guys know very little tunes. They know the tunes that they write. But as far as knowing music, they don't know you know, we came up through an era where people wrote originals, but we had so many lovely standards. I mean so many great tunes out there, you know I wish I were a writer but I'm still trying to get to those great things that have already been written. You know the Broadway show tunes and all of these things. The kids don't have any idea. They don't know. And when they find them or they hear them, they're busy trying to be an individual to the tune until it takes it somewhere else. So they never get the essence of what that tune is about. They just kind of hear it and then they're gone. Because they're driven to have to come up with something. Don't do what he did. Don't be like him. Don't do, you know, it's this kind of thing. So they never connect in that way, which may be the fault of my era of guys, 'cause we kind of split up. The older guys, the Milt Hintons and people stuck together. We kind of started to get a little notoriety and then we scattered like somebody threw a bomb in and we all moved. We don't play together enough you know. This guy forms this group and you never hear Sonny Rollins, Max Roach or those group of guys really playing together any more. They all became leaders.

And they're gone. Which is nice because it gives other people a chance to work off of their situations, but we don't get to hear the great ones and what they were doing. Tomorrow or Saturday there's a Sonny Rollins concert and he's using, on the concert, his, a group of people who grew up in Harlem in a certain neighborhood. The only one, Art Taylor died, so he would ordinarily have been the drummer. But Percy Heath and he's using Gil Coggins, one of the piano players that's worked, what do they call themselves, I forget the part of Harlem, but they live 150s up in there. But they were all neighbors. And Jackie McLean and Sonny Rollins, all of these people, as young guys, played together or experienced different things at the same time, together. So they're kind of a reenactment of, and Walter Bishop, and some of them are going to be on the show. I don't know what they're going to play, I'm not sure what is going to happen yet. But it's a joy just to see that group together. There's some energy in the air. A lot of them haven't played or don't play a lot, but it's just nice to see it, you know. There's something about that kind of professionalism that I think that more young people should see. But we don't have the chance to see it because the older guys kind of are already moved to the side as relics. We only read about the older guys. Bob Cranshaw, I'll be 63, I'm a relic already.

MW: Oh, don't say that now.

BC: Well I mean I'm moving, but I understand, because of the business. So now, talking to younger players, right now I'm working with the union now to get into something else. Because they're not involved in Broadway shows, because they're not involved with the symphonies and the things that are already plugged into the musician's union. I'm trying to see if I can help the union find ways to plug the jazz musicians and the rock musicians into the mainstream so that we don't have to do benefits for a guy when he passes or this kind of thing, but to be able to have the pension and welfare that I'm a part of through the Broadway shows and the T.V. shows, and without even thinking about it. I was saying I used to go in the pit and all the guys would be sitting and they would be talking about the pension and I'm trying to figure out now why are they talking about pensions and stuff, and they're not interested in playing music. I wanted to go and burn. I was ready to cook. I mean I was just thinking about the music. I didn't care whether there was any pension or welfare. I should have been thinking about it. But because I was not plugged in to that situation, I didn't think about it. Now I understand. So I have to make my colleagues from back there and the newer musicians aware that these things are there for them. But I'm trying to get, we have the Lincoln Center Orchestra with Wynton Marsalis, we already got their group involved with the union so that they have things coming. If you're going to belong to the union, the union should be able to do something for you. You should have something coming from it. If not, then I tell a young musician don't join the union. But I say the same thing to the union. Rather than to argue with the union or be

angry at the union for what they don't do, I'm a part of the union. So when they talk about the union they're also talking about me. I'm the part that they're talking about.

MW: And that's good news.

BC: So rather than to get out of it, I got into it. I said okay, I'm not going to fight the union, I have to help the union, but I have to be a liaison between what the union would like to do and what the guys would like to do. And it's easier for me to go and talk to the jazz musicians or the rock musicians 'cause they know me, about a situation, and not do anything unless they want me to do it, rather than having a union representative come in and say, you know, you guys have to do that. I don't like that. My back goes up if they do it to me. So I'm starting to get dialogue going for, we have it for Lincoln Center and we're trying to do it for the Carnegie Hall Orchestra without disturbing what they already have going. Because we have to take into consideration that the George Weins and the people that are supplying so many weeks of work for these people, so it's a working — it's got to be a working thing where it works for the employer and it works for the musicians. But we never had dialogue going between the two vested situations. The union was always going in and saying well you've got to do this, and of course when you tell somebody they've got to do it their back goes up so you start to fight it. Let's talk and see what we have coming, how it's going to benefit the guys before we even think about doing anything. And this is what I'm about. I want to make sure that everybody is going to be covered. Other than that, don't bother me. I don't have anything invested and you can't make my situation work for me through the union then I shouldn't be there, I should be somewhere else where they work for me. And this is what I'm about as a business.

MW: And with that we're going to kind of have to wrap up here, but you've told us some marvelous things. I think you've educated us. I think you've given our students and our listeners some things to hold on to, and I appreciate talking to you, and I really like your talking about the feel. Thank you.

BC: Gotta have that.

MW: Gotta have that feel in that music.

BC: Gotta have that groove, that pocket.

MW: Thank you. This has been our interview with Bob Cranshaw, for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.